49th ANNIVERSARY

CHANDRAYAAN-I, 2008

THE MOONSHOT AND BEYOND

Rakesh Sharma, India's first astronaut, whetted our appetite for space. Chandrayaan-1 made that a reality, and spawned a series of spectacular successes

BY AMARNATH K. MENON

Indians of a certain vintage would not forget that April evening in 1984, spent in front of their black-and-white television sets showing grainy footage of Rakesh Sharma aboard the Soviet spacecraft Soyuz T-11—the first Indian to orbit in space. But though Sharma's famous journey to space station Salyut 7 and back faded in public memory, the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) was planning the nation's initial forays in planetary exploration.

Once India had perfected its launch vehicles—the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV), the Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV) and the GSLV Mk III (LVM3)—to put satellites in orbit, it



GETTY IMAGES

DAWN OF A NEW AGE
A PSLV rocket lifts Chandrayaan-1 into space at Sriharikota, Oct. 22, 2008

127
TOTAL NUMBER
of satellites/ spacecraft launches until Dec. 5, 2024, by ISRO since the satellite Aryabhatta on April 19, 1975